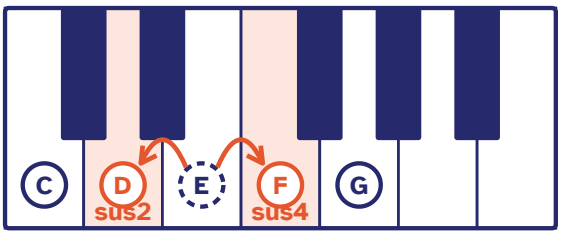
PART IV · CHORDS · 6

Colour chords

The 3rd is the chord's mood: major or minor, happy or sad. Slide it aside, take it away, or add one note, and a plain chord takes on a new colour. Five colours, all from C E G.

THE SECRET

Move the 3rd, take it away, or add one note: five new colours.

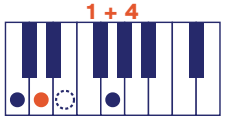


1. Start from **C E G**. The **E** (the 3rd) makes it major.
2. Slide the E up to the next letter, **F**: **Csus4**.
3. Or down to the letter below, **D**: **Csus2**. With no 3rd, the chord is neither major nor minor: it **hangs in the air**.

Five colours, all on C

Csus2

1 + 4



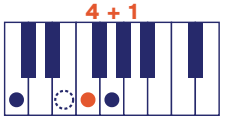
C D G

open

the 3rd steps down

Csus4

4 + 1



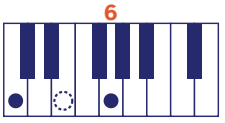
C F G

floating

the 3rd steps up

C5

6



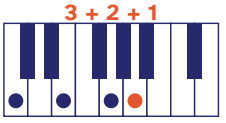
C G

strong

no 3rd at all

C6

3 + 2 + 1



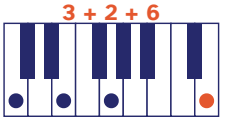
C E G A

warm

add the 6th

Cadd9

3 + 2 + 6

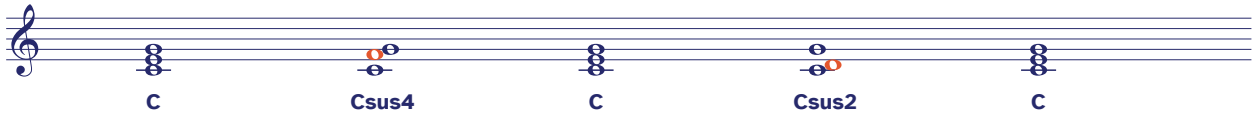


C E G D

sparkly

add the 9th on top

Sus wants to come home



The red note leans, then slides back to E: F steps down, D steps up. Play it slowly: C, Csus4, C, Csus2, C. Guitarists love this shimmer.

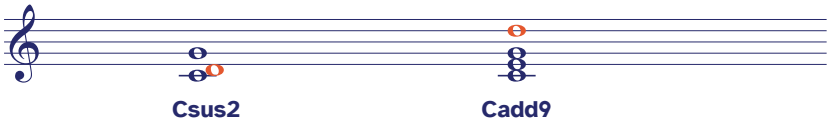
On any root, the counts stay the same

COLOUR	KEYS BETWEEN	ON C	ON G	ON F	ON D
sus2	1 + 4	C D G	G A D	F G C	D E A
sus4	4 + 1	C F G	G C D	F B♭ C	D G A
5	6	C G	G D	F C	D A
6	3 + 2 + 1	C E G **A**	G B D **E**	F A C **D**	D F♯ A **B**
add9	3 + 2 + 6	C E G **D**	G B D **A**	F A C **G**	D F♯ A **E**

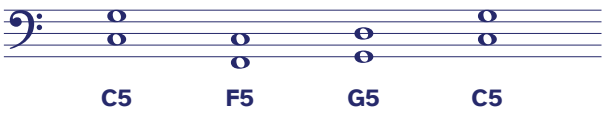
PART IV · CHORDS · 6 · CONTINUED

sus: the 3rd held up or down · **5**: no 3rd at all · **6** and **add9**: one note added on top. Csus means Csus4.

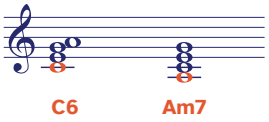
Spot the difference



The same red D, two jobs. Csus2 throws the E out; Cadd9 keeps the E and puts the D on top.



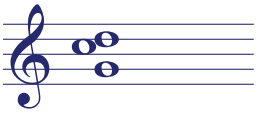
The power chord: just the root and the 5th, played low in the left hand. With no 3rd it is neither happy nor sad, only **strong**: the sound of rock guitar. Play C5, F5, G5, C5 and drum the rhythm.



C6 or Am7? The same four notes, C E G A. The red bottom note decides: C at the bottom is **C6**; A at the bottom is **Am7**. More on the bass note in Slash chords, p. 107.

EXAMPLE 1

Which colour is it? G C D



1. **Count the keys between:** G to C is 4, C to D is 1.
2. **4 + 1** is the sus4 card: no B (no 3rd), and C has taken its place.
3. **The root is G:** Gsus4.

G C D is **Gsus4**. Let the C fall to **B** and you have G major.

GAME

sus2, sus4 or add9?

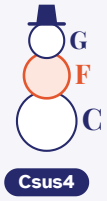
1	2	3
C D G	C F G	C E G D

In a sus chord the 3rd has moved; in an add chord nothing moved and a note was added.

Answer: 1 Csus2 · 2 Csus4 · 3 Cadd9.

PART IV · CHORDS · 6 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Csus4, then C.

Play C F G, then let the F slide down to E. The sus chord waits; the plain chord arrives.

EXAMPLE 2

Build Dsus4

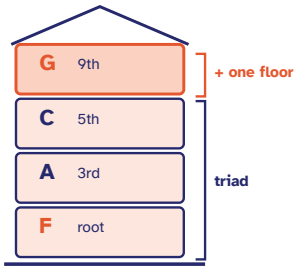


1. **Start with D major:** D F♯ A.
2. **Lift the 3rd, F♯, up a step** to G.
3. **D G A** waits; let the G fall back to F♯ to finish.

Dsus4: **D G A**, then home to D F♯ A.

EXAMPLE 3

Build Fadd9



1. **Start with F major:** F A C.
2. **Keep every note.**
3. **Add the 9th:** G, the note just above F, placed on top.

Fadd9: **F A C G**. Nothing moved; one note was added.

THINK OF IT Dressing the snowman: a scarf (the 6th) or a hat (the 9th) and it is still the same snowman. Sus moves its middle ball; a power chord takes the middle ball away.

TRAP

- × Writing C2: some books mean Csus2, others Cadd9. Check whether the E is there.
- × Calling Cadd9 a ninth chord: C9 also has the 7th (B♭). Add9 is just the triad plus the 9th (D on C), nothing else (The tower, p. 104).

SEE ALSO
Four kinds of triad p. 89 · Seventh chords p. 98

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 6 · Online: Library › Chords